

DOWN POSTAL LANE
A child posts a letter at the Daakrom event in Chandigarh

The Benefits of Handwritten Communication

EMOTIONAL REGULATION

- A study published in *JMIR Mental Health* in 2018, which involved 70 adults with elevated anxiety, found that writing in a journal led to decreased mental distress after a month and greater resilience after the first and second month, relative to usual care
- A study published in the *Journal of Behavioral Medicine* in 2008 traced the impact of writing on 102 chronic pain patients and found greater improvements in control over pain and depressed mood

TREATING LONELINESS

- Nearly 60 per cent Indians between the ages of 18 and 29 felt lonely during the Covid-19 pandemic, according to a study published in the *Journal of Positive School Psychology* in 2022. That's concerning because loneliness can increase the risk of heart attack by 29 per cent and of stroke by 32 per cent, says the American Heart Association. Letter writing can help in such cases, as it reduces the impact of loneliness and can help establish a sense of social connection, as was found in a 2021 research study published in the *Journal of Social Work* in 2021.

LEARNING AND MEMORY

- Writing by hand creates more activity in the sensorimotor parts of the brain, as well as the hippocampus, which is associated with higher recall, according to experts
- A 2021 study by the Norwegian University of Science and Technology, which tracked brain activity during classroom learning, found that cursive writing produces the best learning and memory
- A 2021 study from Johns Hopkins notes that writing by hand helps adults learn general literacy skills faster than when they learn the same material by typing or watching videos

"When the children saw the postman, they began running after him as he left with the post. It was a deeply emotional moment. The postman himself got teary-eyed.... How often does that happen in digital communication?" Before each carnival, Daakroom runs school programmes for a month or two. "The purpose is to get young people excited about something that seems so quaint, old-fashioned and yet is so powerful at expressing oneself," says Mehta.

Upasana Chaddha, a Delhi-based psychologist, says writing can help those who cannot articulate their emotions as it provides them with a non-judgemental space to express themselves. A report published in *JMIR Mental Health* in 2018, which studied 70 adults with elevated anxiety, found that journaling was associated with decreased mental distress. A 2013 study in PubMed also noted that expressive writing helped in managing depression and that the benefits lasted even four weeks after the experiment.

Not just mental health, handwritten communication is shown to improve physical wellbeing too. In a 2004 study published in *Psychosom Med*, 37 HIV-infected patients were asked to write for 30 minutes a day. Measured at baseline and two weeks, three months and six months after the writing exercise, it was seen that the count of white blood cells increased after the intervention and viral loads dropped. Similarly, a study published in the *Journal of Behavioral Medicine* in 2008 analysed the impact of writing on 102 chronic pain patients and found that writing led to greater improvements in control over pain and depressed mood and marginally greater improvements in pain severity. "The impact of handwriting is not universal," says Dr C.S. Narayanan, head of the department of neurology at HCMCT Manipal Hospital in Delhi. "But for those comfortable with the handwritten word, writing letters or in diaries can certainly help improve wellbeing."

Many psychologists now use writing as part of their treatment plans. "It does work for most patients, so we try it first,"